

The Secret Workshop and the Silver Star

Hidden treasure story • 11-12 years old



Chapter 1: The Map in the Attic

Maya found the paper by accident, folded into the pocket of a sweater she had almost thrown away. It crackled like a dry leaf when she opened it. Lines of ink made a map of their town, but the streets were drawn like rivers twisting into hills, and there was a little drawing of a star where the map stopped.

—Look at this, Isla! —Maya whispered, running her finger along the curled edge.

Isla leaned over, hair falling into her face. Her eyes lit up the way they did before a daring plan. —A treasure map? Or a secret recipe for the best hot chocolate ever?

They laughed, but the laughter tasted like wind in an empty room: excited, a little nervous. At the bottom of the paper, there was a note in a careful hand: « **Treasure guarded by riddles. Respect the keeper. Respect the place.** »

—Keeper? —Isla frowned. —Who keeps a treasure?

—Maybe someone who likes puzzles, —Maya said. —Or someone who wants to teach people to be clever and kind.

The attic smelled of dust and lavender. Below them, the house creaked as if listening. They both knew their town well—every bakery, every lane—and already the map suggested a route they had never seen. It started at the old willow by the river and ended at the star.

—We should do it, —Isla said, voice serious and thrilled. —A proper hunt. Just the two of us.

Maya squeezed her friend's shoulder. —We always find our way out of trouble together. Let's be careful. Respect the keeper. Respect the place.

They packed: torches, a pocket knife, a notebook, a small first-aid kit, and two sandwiches, because adventures were always hungrier than ordinary days.

Chapter 2: The Willow's Whisper

The willow sighed over the river like an old storyteller. Its long leaves skimmed the water. Beneath it, a stone bench had a plaque that read: Remember the quiet.

The first riddle was tucked beneath the bench, like a secret waiting to be told.

It said: « **I have a beginning without end, a face without a mouth. Turn me around and I still watch. What am I? »**

Isla read it twice. —A moon? —she guessed. —But the moon has—

Maya traced the letters with her finger. —A clock! —she said suddenly. —A circle, a face, hands that watch you. Turn it around—it's still a clock.

They both smiled. Solving the riddle clicked something warm in their chests, like finding a corner of a puzzle. Under the stone the map folded back to reveal a tiny compass rose and the next direction: « **North by the old mill.** »

As they walked, the river gurgled like a secret. They passed a boy skipping stones and an old woman feeding bread to ducks; Maya waved and Isla tipped an imaginary hat. Respect threaded through every small action: they were careful not to frighten the ducks, and they thanked the woman when she pointed them to the path by the mill.

The old mill creaked and belonged to the town in the way old things do—everyone knew it but no one could remember the last time its wheel turned. The next clue was not a riddle at first, but a test of patience: a locked iron gate and a note that read, « **Ask permission.** »

—We could climb, —Isla suggested, eyes on the gate.

—We could, —Maya agreed, then shook her head. —But the paper said respect the keeper. Maybe we should ask.

They walked to the farmhouse nearby. An elderly man with hands like folded maps answered the door. He listened while they explained. He smiled when they said they wanted to respect the place.

—My name is Mr. Holloway, —he said. —Long ago I tended the mill. The treasure? I know nothing, but riddles do like clever feet. Go on through. But leave the gates as you find them.

He unlocked the gate and handed them a small brass key. —This might be useful. And remember: respect is a kind of courage too.

They thanked him and felt the key warm in Maya's palm. It felt like a promise.

Chapter 3: The Bridge of Stones

The path led them to a field of stones, smooth and wet from a recent rain. Each stone had a letter carved into it. Across the field, a slim, old bridge arched like a smile. Hanging from the bridge was a lantern that would not light, but beneath the lantern was a riddle painted in gold.

« I speak without a voice, I fly without wings. I am written and read and sometimes torn. What am I? »

Isla crouched and read the letters on the stones aloud: « **P-A-G-E...** » Her face brightened. —Pages! A book! It's words that fly and breathe on paper.

—We need to step on the stones in the right order, —Maya said, eyes scanning. —There might be many paths, but only one spells the next clue.

They tested steps, sometimes wobbling, sometimes laughing when they nearly slipped. It took courage and patience to choose the right stones. When they reached the other side, a brass plate under the lantern read: « **Books show what we cannot see. The next lies where time keeps watch.** »

They crossed the bridge and found the mill's clocktower looming up ahead, its face cracked like a smile. A small door at its base was locked, but the brass key fit perfectly.

Inside, stairs spiraled upward. Dust danced like tiny planets. At the top, the clock hands pointed to a riddle pasted on the inner wall:

« **Turn me once, I will live. Turn me twice, I will die. What am I?** »

Isla hummed, thinking of things that change with motion.

—A key? —she guessed. —You turn it once to lock or unlock...

Maya looked at the old gears. —Or a page—one turn of a page can start a story, another can end it. But maybe—it's a light. A switch. Turn it on, it lives; off, it dies.

Isla nodded slowly. They found a rusty switch in the shadow. Maya's hand hovered before she flipped it. A sliver of sunlight, released by the shutters, spilled into the tower and the old clock ticked like a relieved throat. Hidden in the glow was a slim wooden box. Inside lay a small silver coin engraved with a single star and a note: « **The star is not a place. It is a promise.** »

They pocketed the coin. The climb had been hard on their knees, and they laughed at how loud their breathing sounded upstairs. The clock ticked on, steady as a heartbeat.

Chapter 4: The Market Librarian

The coin led them back down the streets, where the market buzzed like a wasp nest. Stalls sold jars of honey, knitted scarves, and jars filled with the smell of oranges. At the market's edge sat a tiny bookstall, and behind it a woman with spectacles that slid to the end of her nose. Her hair was piled like a cloud and she had the steady, welcoming way of someone who had read many ends of many stories.

—Do you have any idea what a star-coin means? —Maya asked, holding it out.

The librarian squinted, then smiled. —Ah. The Treasure of Riddles often leads to things people lose when they become too busy—curiosity, kindness, the time to make something with your hands. But if it led you here, perhaps the next riddle is about listening.

She pointed to a crate beside the stall where birds fluttered, carrying seeds. A scrap of paper hung from the crate: « **Where voices gather but do not speak, where hands make and keep, the answer rests.** »

—A workshop, —Isla guessed. —Where people speak with their hands.

—Yes, a workshop where things are made, —Maya breathed. —Which one here?

The librarian gestured toward the end of the market, where a green awning marked the Old Workshop. It used to be busy with wood and cloth. Now it was quiet, its windows dusty.

—The keeper of that place might be the one who left the map, —the librarian said. —Go and ask. Be respectful. If you are kind to the tools, they will be kind to you.

They pushed the workshop door open. Inside, tools lay like sleeping animals. There was a large table stained with paint and glue. On the table, a riddle was pinned under a paperweight:

« **I have keys but no locks, I have space but no room. You can enter, but you**

can't go inside. What am I? »

Isla tapped her chin. —A keyboard? —she guessed, remembering the old computer in the school library.

They tried the old keyboard tucked under the table. When Isla pressed the spacebar, the drawer beneath the table clicked and slid open. Inside was a hand-drawn map of the town at dawn, with an X painted where a tiny garden lay hidden behind the library. Attached was a small note: « **The treasure blooms where respect is planted.** »

Chapter 5: The Garden of Answers

The garden was quieter than a secret. Tucked behind the library, it had been a sun trap of flowers once. Now it was tangled, with ivy taking over benches and old pots cracked like whispered laughter. Butterflies still threaded the air, stubborn as hope.

At its center was a sundial, misaligned, its shadow pointing to a stone slab. The slab bore the last riddle, written in a hand that trembled like tree branches: « **What is won by giving and kept by sharing?** »

Both girls looked at each other, and the answer bloomed at once.

—Respect? —Maya said softly.

—No, —Isla shook her head. —Love? —she tried, then frowned. —No, that's too big. Trust?

They sat on the bench and watched a child chase a beetle. Then Maya remembered Mr. Holloway's words and the librarian's. The treasures had been about more than coins and keys. They were about how people treated places and one another.

—Kindness, —Maya said. —Or memory. Or work done together. If you give help, then others can keep it by sharing it forward.

Isla smiled. —Maybe the answer is friendship. We both give and keep it.

They placed their hands together over the slab, and the ground beneath the sundial shifted with a sigh. The stone slid aside like a lid, revealing a small cavity. Inside sat a wooden chest the size of a loaf of bread. It did not gleam with gold, but it carried a warmth, like the warm side of a pillow.

They opened it carefully. Inside were neatly folded cloths, jars of bright paint, brushes, repaired tools wrapped in oilcloth, and a notebook filled with plans for a community workshop. On the lid's underside was written: « **Build, share, respect. Keep it clean. Keep it open.** »

Maya and Isla looked at each other, breathless. The treasure had been a set of things, yes, but more than that it was an invitation.

Chapter 6: The Clean Workshop

They took the chest back to the old workshop and began to work. They scrubbed the tables, cleaned the windows until they shone like glass rivers, and hung the repaired tools on the wall, each in its place. They mended chairs, swept the floor, and painted a sign: « **Community Workshop — All Welcome. Respect.** »

Neighbors came by, at first curious, then smiling, then rolling up their sleeves. Mr. Holloway brought tea and stories. The librarian donated books about making things, and the woman who fed ducks offered jars of seed beads. Children learned to use hammers and needles under patient eyes. Teenagers taught younger kids how to sew, carve, and print. People respected the place and each other; tools were used carefully, the floor was swept at the end of every day, and laughter became a common sound.

When the workshop was ready, Maya and Isla organized a little opening. They placed the silver star-coin on the worktable and explained how they had found it. They told the story of riddles and the importance of asking permission, of listening, and of sharing.

—The treasure wasn't meant for hiding, —Maya told the assembled crowd. —It was here to be found and to become other people's treasure too.

Isla added, —We promised to be respectful along the way. That promise is what kept the path open.

The workshop stayed clean, not because someone demanded it, but because everyone felt responsible. They called it a clean workshop, a place where things were fixed and made, where respect lived in how the chairs were mended and how each voice was heard.

At the end of that first day, they sat on the steps, tired but full. The sun dipped low, painting the town in orange and gold. Maya took the little notebook from the chest and wrote beside the map: « **Treasure found. Lesson kept.** »

—Do you think the keeper will be pleased? —Isla asked.

—I hope so, —Maya said. —But the important thing is, we tried to be kind and smart and brave together.

They could hear the hum of the workshop behind them—a steady, gentle sound of people making things and learning. The town felt smaller and kinder, stitched a little closer by hands that had learned to work and to respect.

Before they went home, they placed the silver coin back into the chest and covered it with a cloth. They left a new note inside the lid: « **For the next seekers: the real treasure grows when you give it away.** »

They locked the workshop for the night and walked home under a canopy of stars, each step a quiet drumbeat of an adventure finished and a promise

beginning.

The quiz: did you understand the story well?

1) What was the first riddle that Maya and Isla found under the willow tree?

- What is won by giving and kept by sharing?
- I have keys but no locks, I have space but no room.
- I speak without a voice, I fly without wings.
- I have a beginning without end, a face without a mouth.

2) What did Mr. Holloway give Maya and Isla when they asked about the treasure?

- A locked box
- A brass key
- A map of the town
- A jar of honey

3) What did the small wooden box found in the clock tower contain?

- Gold coins
- A map leading to more treasures
- Plans for a community workshop
- A book of riddles

4) What does the phrase 'Respect the keeper. Respect the place.' mean in the story?

- Being careful with the treasure
- Listening to adults
- Taking care of where they traveled and the people they met
- Solving riddles quickly

5) What did Maya and Isla decide to do with the treasure they found?

- Hide it away for themselves
- Share it with the townspeople
- Use it to buy new tools
- Sell it for money

6) What lesson did Maya and Isla learn from their adventure?

- Always trust strangers
- The importance of teamwork and kindness

- Treasure is only about money
- Riddles are only for fun

Correct answers:

1) *I have a beginning without end, a face without a mouth.* 2) *A brass key* 3) *Plans for a community workshop* 4) *Taking care of where they traveled and the people they met* 5) *Share it with the townspeople* 6) *The importance of teamwork and kindness*

Glossary: complicated words in the story

Cavity: A hollow space inside something, like a hole or an opening.

Invitation: A request for someone to go somewhere or do something.

Respect: A feeling of admiration for someone or something because of their qualities or achievements.

Responsible: Having the duty to take care of something or someone; being in charge.

Treasure: Valuable things such as gold, jewels, or any precious items, or something very special.

Community: A group of people living in the same place or having a common characteristic.